



PL-7008: Create agents in Microsoft Copilot Studio



Module 2: Manage topics in Microsoft Copilot Studio



Microsoft Learn module

Manage topics in Microsoft Copilot Studio

<https://learn.microsoft.com/training/modules/manage-power-virtual-agents-topics>



Learning Objectives

After completing this module, you will be able to:

1 Create topics in Microsoft Copilot Studio

2 Add trigger phrases

3 Disable topics

4 Delete sample topics

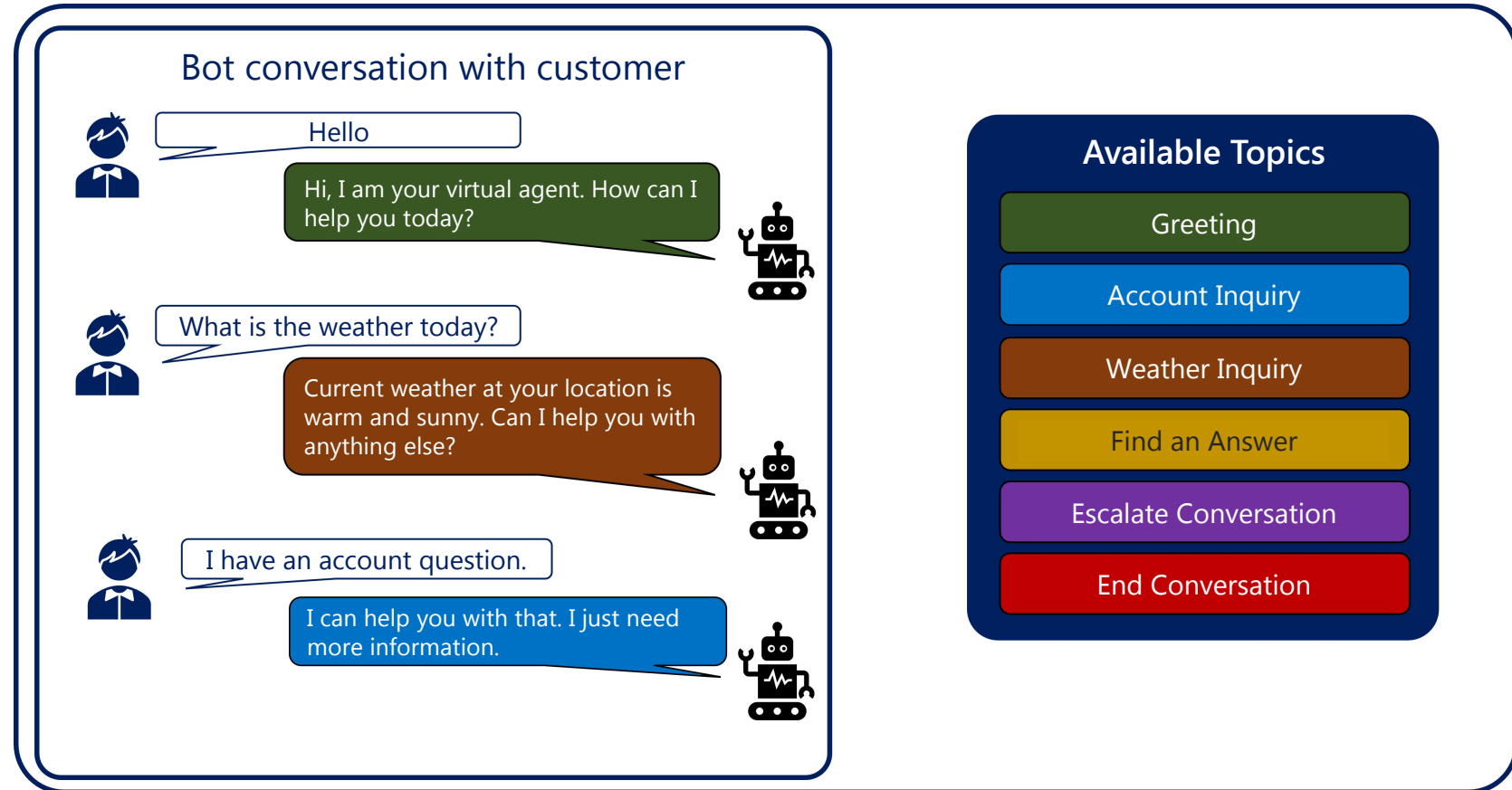
5 Configure nodes

Create topics in Microsoft Copilot Studio



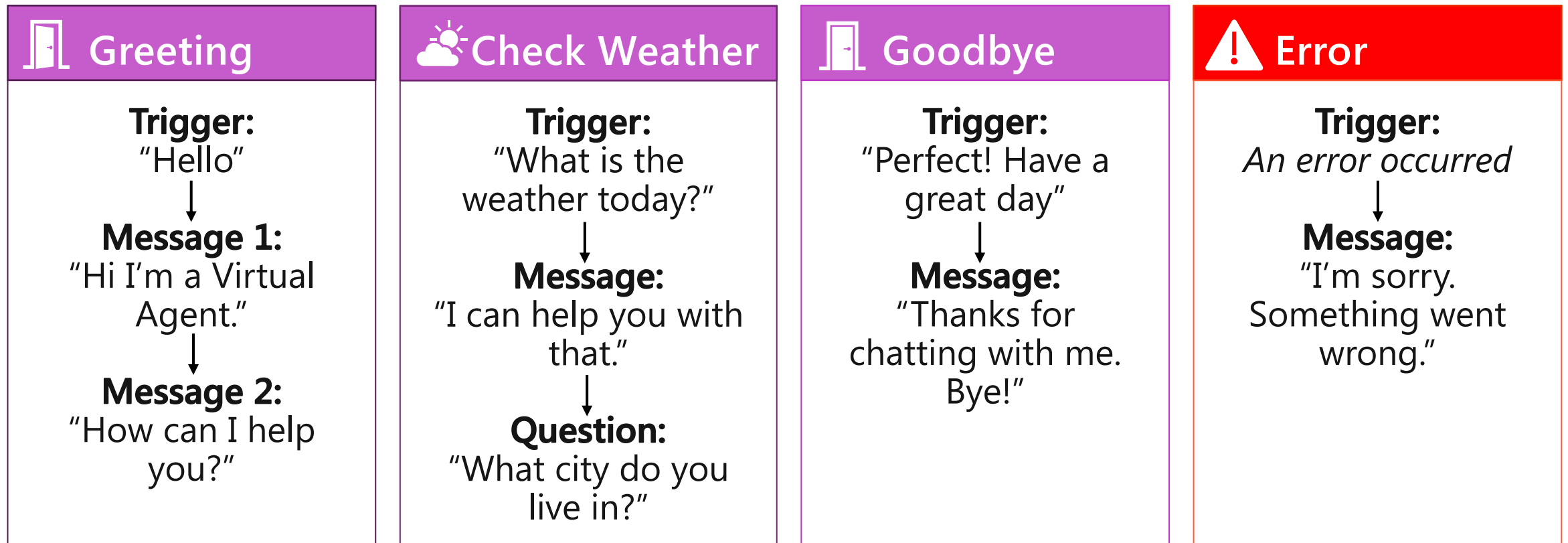
Conversations in agents

- Each topic is a small individual conversation on a specific subject
- Multiple topics can be used together in a single agent to provide the customer with an automated conversation that feels natural and flows appropriately



Topics in Copilot Studio

- **Topics** define dialog flows for agent interaction
- They are initiated by **triggers**, which can be user input or events such as errors



Authoring topics in Copilot Studio



From blank: Create topics by adding trigger phrases

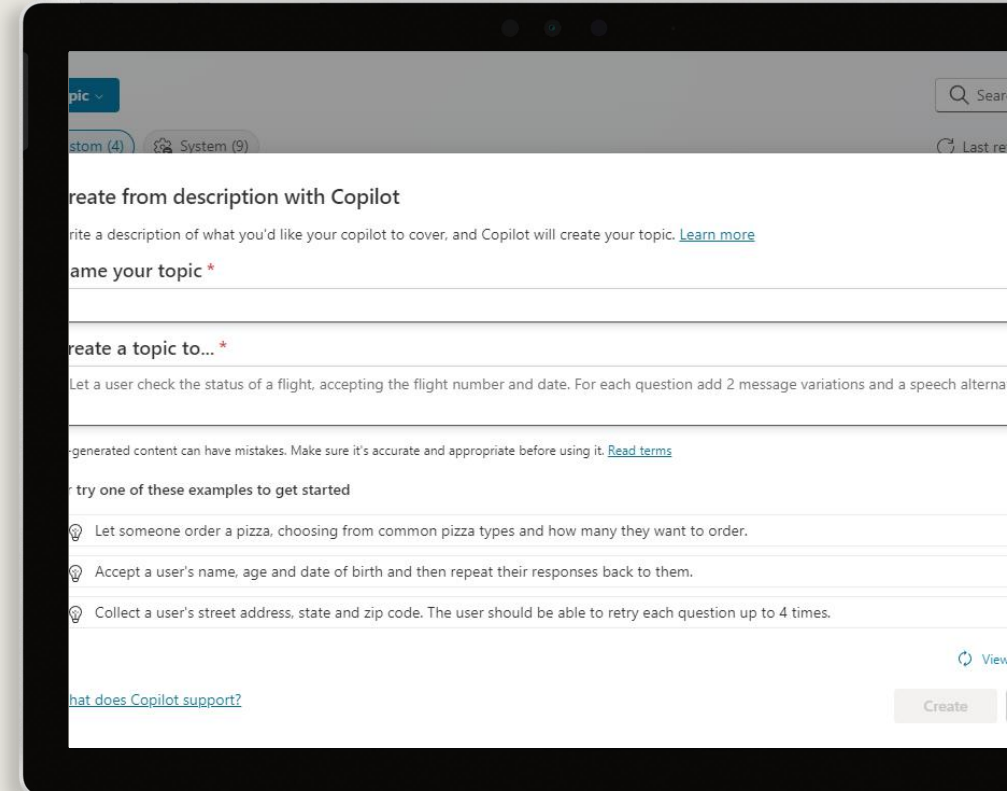


Using Copilot: Author topics using natural language

Author topics using natural language

Create from description

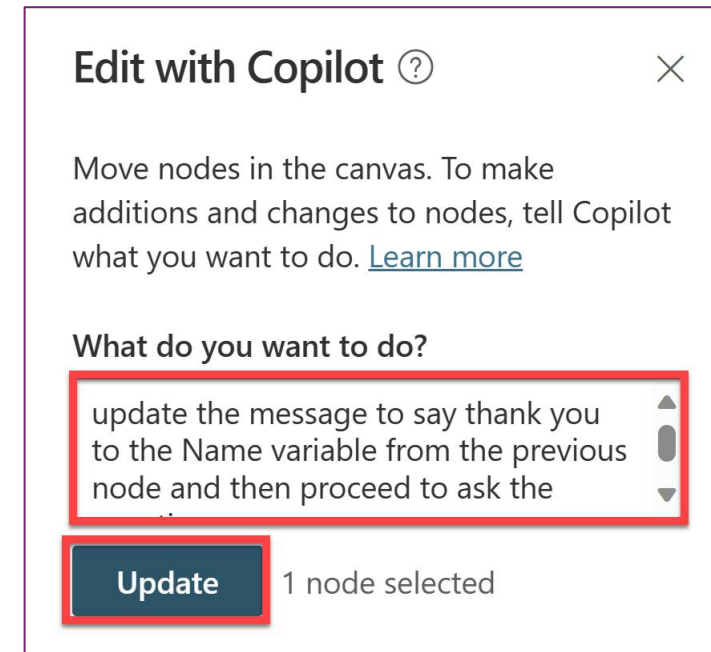
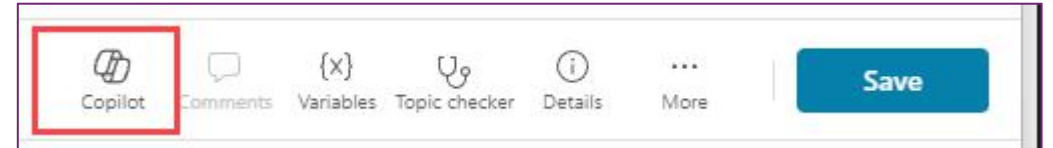
- Describe the topic in natural language
- Topic is created with conversational responses and multiple types of nodes



Update nodes with natural language

Change topic

- Select Copilot icon
- Select a node to change a node
- Select canvas to add a node
- Edit with Copilot pane
- Describe what you would like to change
- Use simple, plain language to direct the AI



Demo - Create a topic with Copilot



Demo

Example: Topic created with Copilot

Real Estate Booking Service

OverviewKnowledgeTopicsActionsAnalyticsChannels

Published 7/14/2024

PublishSettings

Test

Customer Details

CopilotCommentsVariablesTopic checkerDetailsMore

Save

Trigger

Phrases

customer details
get customer information
retrieve customer details
customer profile
view customer data

Question

What is your full name?

Identify

Person name

Save user response as

FullNamestring

Question

What do you want to do?

Explain what you want to change or add from the topic. Select a node to be more specific.

UpdateNo nodes selected

What you asked for

"Ask the customer for their full name and email address"

What we added

Question
What is your full name?

Question
What is your email address?

Examples that work

Add a question to ask the user for their name.

Summarize the information gathered from the user in an Adaptive Card.

Add a question to ask the user to choose their preferred contact method, choosing from email, telephone or SMS.

Trigger phrases



What are trigger phrases in Copilot Studio?



Trigger phrases train your agent's natural language understanding (NLU) model



Trigger phrases are configured at the topic level and indicate to the agent for what typical user utterances a specific topic should be triggered



Trigger phrases typically capture the way an end-user would ask about a problem or issue

Demo - Create a topic with trigger phrases



Demo

Example: Topic with trigger phrases

The screenshot displays the Microsoft Bot Framework Composer interface. On the left, a canvas shows a 'Trigger' node with a lightning bolt icon and a three-dot menu. Below it is a 'User says a phrase' node with a person icon and an 'Edit' link. Underneath that is a 'Phrases' node with the text 'No phrases to show'. A plus sign in a circle is positioned below the 'Phrases' node. On the right, a settings panel is open for the 'On Recognized Intent' trigger. It includes a 'Phrases' section with explanatory text and a 'Show writing tips' link. Below this is an 'Add phrases' section with more explanatory text, a text input field labeled 'Enter text', and a plus button. At the bottom of the panel is an 'Advanced' section with a chevron icon.

Trigger

User says a phrase
[Edit](#)

Phrases
No phrases to show

On Recognized Intent

Phrases

To start learning, the agent needs 5-10 short trigger phrases.

[Show writing tips](#)

Add phrases

Phrases teach the agent different ways someone might ask about this topic. Natural language understanding helps identify a topic based on meaning and not exact words.

Enter text

To add items in bulk, paste in line-separated items or use Shift+Enter to create line separation or [upload a file](#) | [download](#)

> Advanced

Best practices for trigger phrases

- At least 5-10 trigger phrases per topic
- Vary sentence structure and key terms
- Use short trigger phrases
- Avoid single-word trigger phrases
- Have unique verbs and nouns (or a combination)
- Avoid using the same entity variation

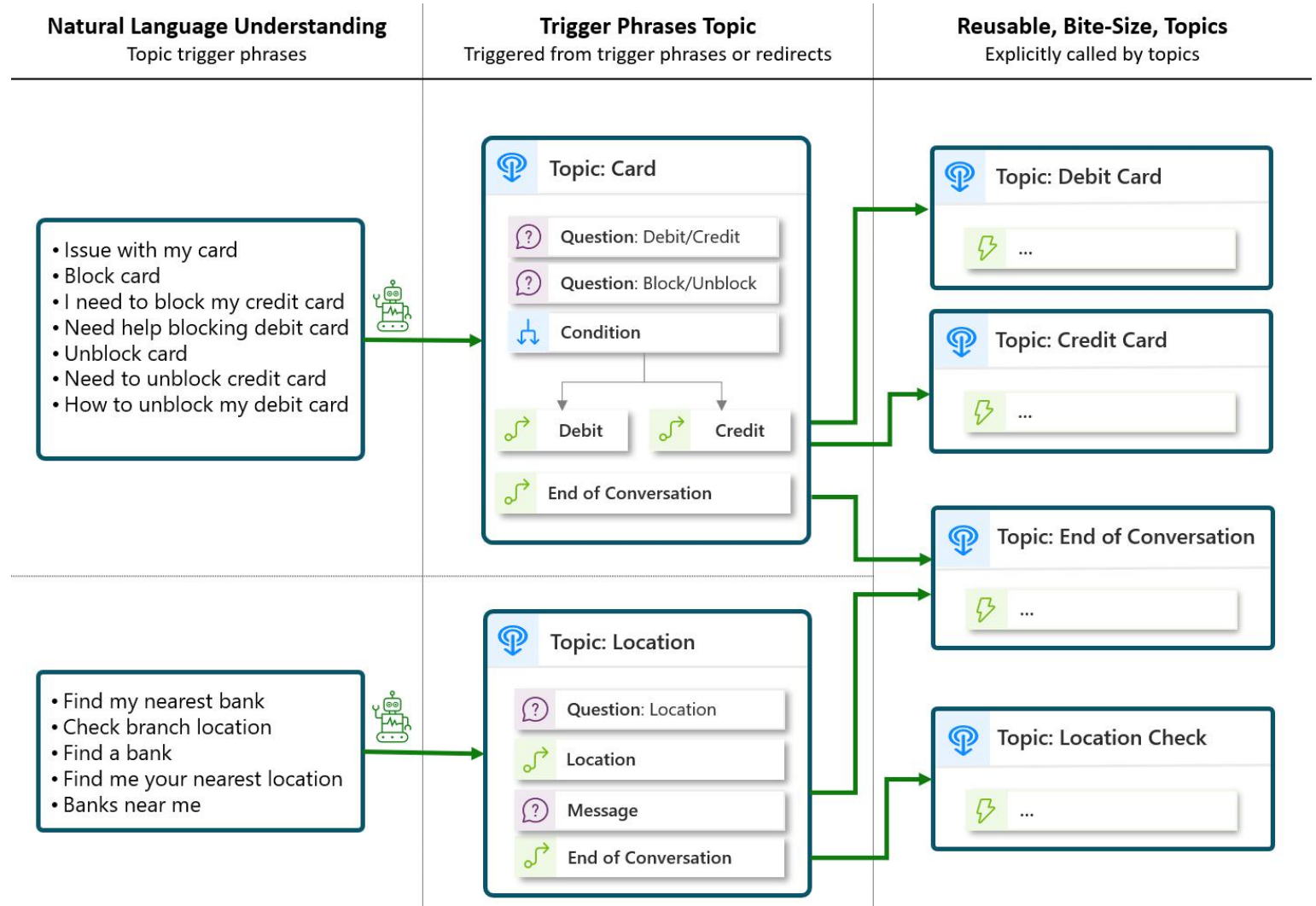
Manage topics



Authoring in Copilot Studio

Topic best practices

- Create and organize topics in a way that's manageable and maintainable for your context
- Create bite-size topics
- Create reusable topics
- Avoid topic overlap
- Use entities to reduce the number of topics



System topics

- 1** **Conversation Start:** Greets users and introduces the agent and its capabilities. Triggers when an agent first engages with a user in conversation.

- 2** **Conversational boosting:** Creates generative answers from external data sources. Triggers when the agent can't find a match for the user query

- 3** **End of Conversation:** Confirms with customers that their query is answered. Triggers from a redirection. Call this topic from your custom topics when you're ready to end a conversation.

- 4** **Escalate:** Informs customers if they need to speak with a human. Triggers when "talk to agent" is matched or the Escalate system event is called.

- 5** **Fallback:** Informs users their query couldn't be matched to a topic and asks them to try again. Triggers when the agent can't match the user's question or message to a topic.

System topics

6

Multiple Topics Matched: Prompts users to choose their intended topic and sets a system variable to identify the topic triggered. Triggers when a user's message closely matches multiple topics.

7

On Error: Informs customers that an error occurred. Triggers when an error occurs during the conversation.

8

Reset Conversation: Resets the conversation by clearing variable values and forcing the agent to use the latest published agent content. Triggers with a redirection.

9

Sign in: Prompts customers to sign in when user authentication is enabled. Triggers at the beginning of the conversation when users are required to sign in, or when the conversation reaches a node that uses authentication variables.

Manage topics

Delete topics

- Remove topics not required

Name	Trigger
 Goodbye	 Phrases
 Greeting	 Phrases
 Lesson 1 - A simple topic	 Phrases
 Lesson 2 - A simple topic with a cor	 Details  Make a Copy  Delete
 Lesson 3 - A topic with a condition,	
 Start Over	
 Thank you	 Phrases

Disable topics

- Turn off topics not required

Build copilots OverviewKnowledgeTopicsActionsAnalyticsChannels						
+ Add a topic All Custom (7) System (9) Search custom topics Last refreshed now						
Name	Trigger	Description	Editing	Last modified	Errors	Enabled
 Goodbye	 Phrases	This topic triggers ...		MOD Administrat...		On
 Greeting	 Phrases	This topic is trigger...		MOD Administrat...		On
 Lesson 1 - A simple topic	 Phrases			MOD Administrat...		On
 Lesson 2 - A simple topic with a condi...	 Phrases			MOD Administrat...		On
 Lesson 3 - A topic with a condition, va...	 Phrases			MOD Administrat...		On
 Start Over	 Phrases			MOD Administrat...		On
 Thank you	 Phrases	This topic triggers ...		MOD Administrat...		On

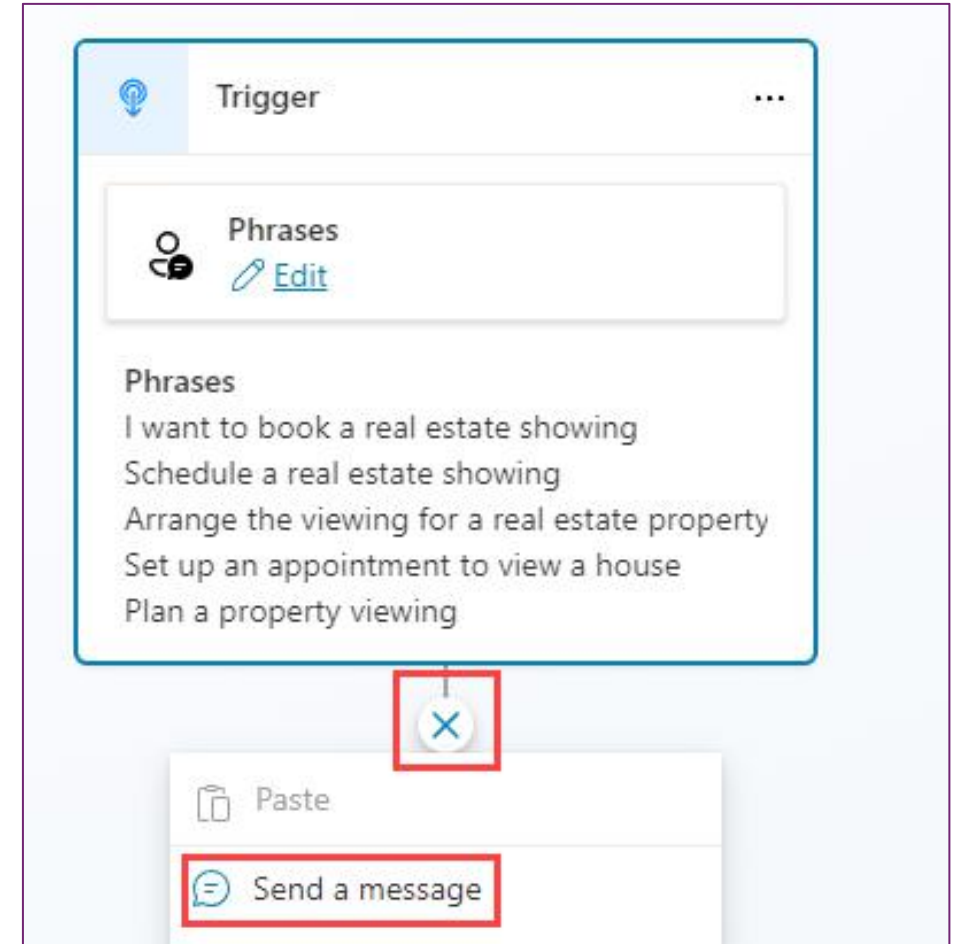
Configure nodes



Conversation nodes

Add node

- Conversation nodes represent customer interactions or actions that can be inserted into a topic's conversation path
- Trigger phrase node included in new topics
- Click on the + icon to add further nodes



Node types

1

Send a message: Displays a message to the user. Messages can include some basic formatting and numbering.

2

Ask a question: Helps the agent capture information from the user. The captured information can be used to influence the flow of the conversation, or as variables in other parts of the agent.

3

Ask with adaptive card: Enables you to add a JSON snippet that can also be openly exchanged with other cloud apps and services.

4

Add a condition: Allows you to add a condition to the topic flow. This can be used to direct users down specific paths based on if the condition is met or not.

Node types

6

Variable management: Set a value, parse a value, or clear all variables.

7

Topic management: Redirect the user to a different topic in the agent, transfer to a live agent, or end the topic or conversation.

8

Call an action: Calls a Power Automate cloud flow to help interact with external system.

9

Advanced: Generative answers, HTTP requests, events, and more.

Question node

Question properties

- **Ask a question:** The question text that you want to present to the user.
- **Identify:** Defines what the agent should be listening for in the user's response.
 - User's entire response
 - Entity
- **Save response as:** Variable

Variable properties

Variable name
PropertyName

Type
string

Reference
Question
Which property do you want to see?
Type (string) derived from here
Variable gets value from this node if empty
[View all references](#)

Usage
☒ Topic (limited scope)
☐ Receive values from other topics
☐ Return values to original topics
☐ Global (any topic can access)

Question node

Using closed list entity

- Choose a closed list entity for Identify
- Must select the list values from entity

What type of property do you want to...

Identify

 Property Type >

Select options for user

Options for user

Apartment

House

Condominium

Duplex

User options for Property Type

 Search

List values (4) Display

Apartment	☒
House	☒
Condominium	☒
Duplex	☒

Question node

Question behavior

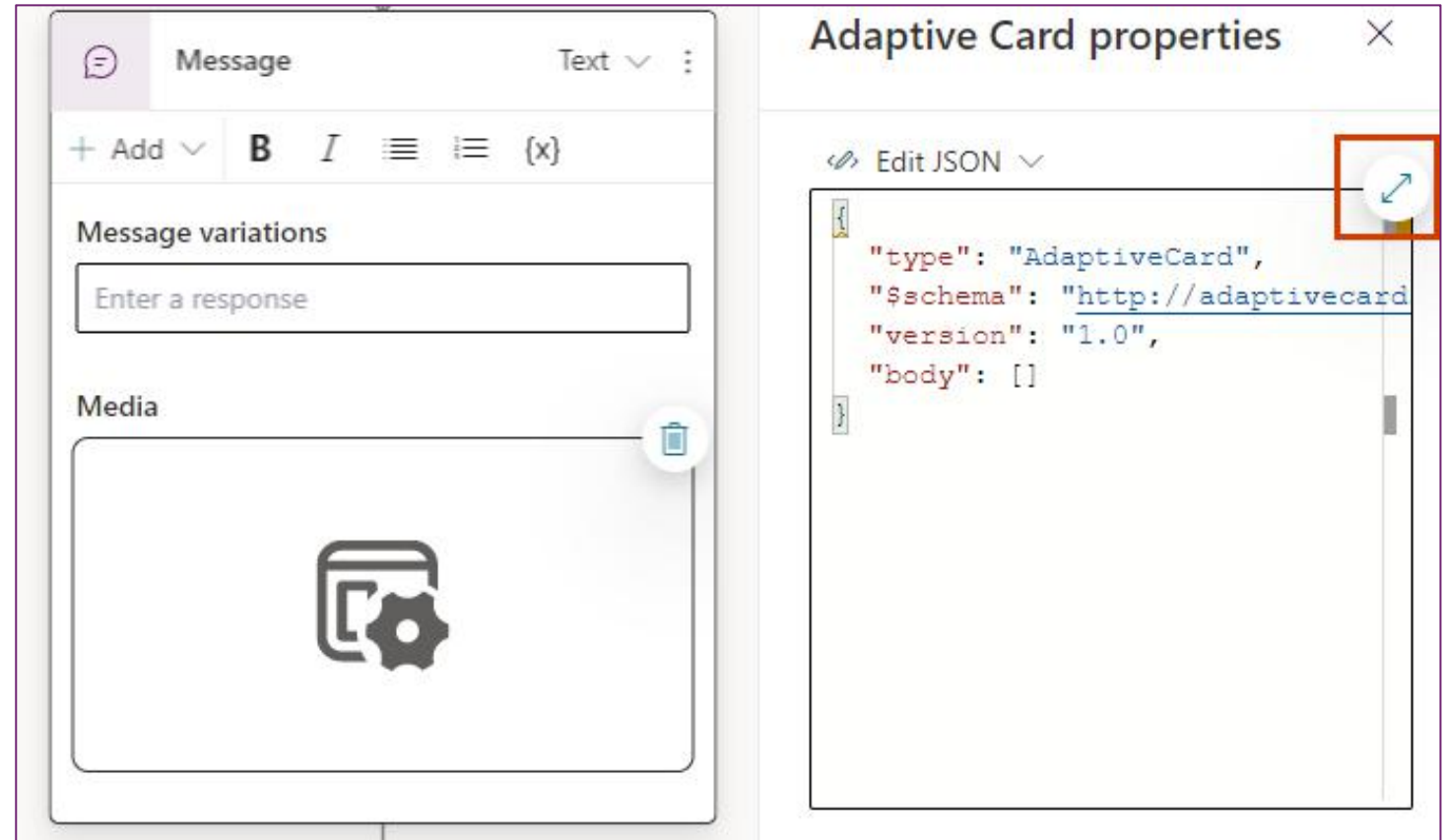
- Skip behavior
- Reprompt
- Additional entity validation
- No valid entity found
- Interruptions

The screenshot displays the Bot Framework Designer interface. On the left, a 'Question' node is shown in a flowchart. The node has a 'Text' dropdown menu set to 'Text', which is highlighted with a red box. Below the node, the text 'Booking date?' is visible. Underneath, there is an 'Identify' section with a 'Date and time' entity type selected. Below that, the 'Save response as' section shows a variable 'bookingDate' of type 'datetime'. On the right, the 'Question properties' panel is open, showing the 'Question behavior' section, which is also highlighted with a red box. The text in this section reads: 'Control how your bot asks this question and identifies the entity.'

Adaptive Card node

Adaptive Card Properties

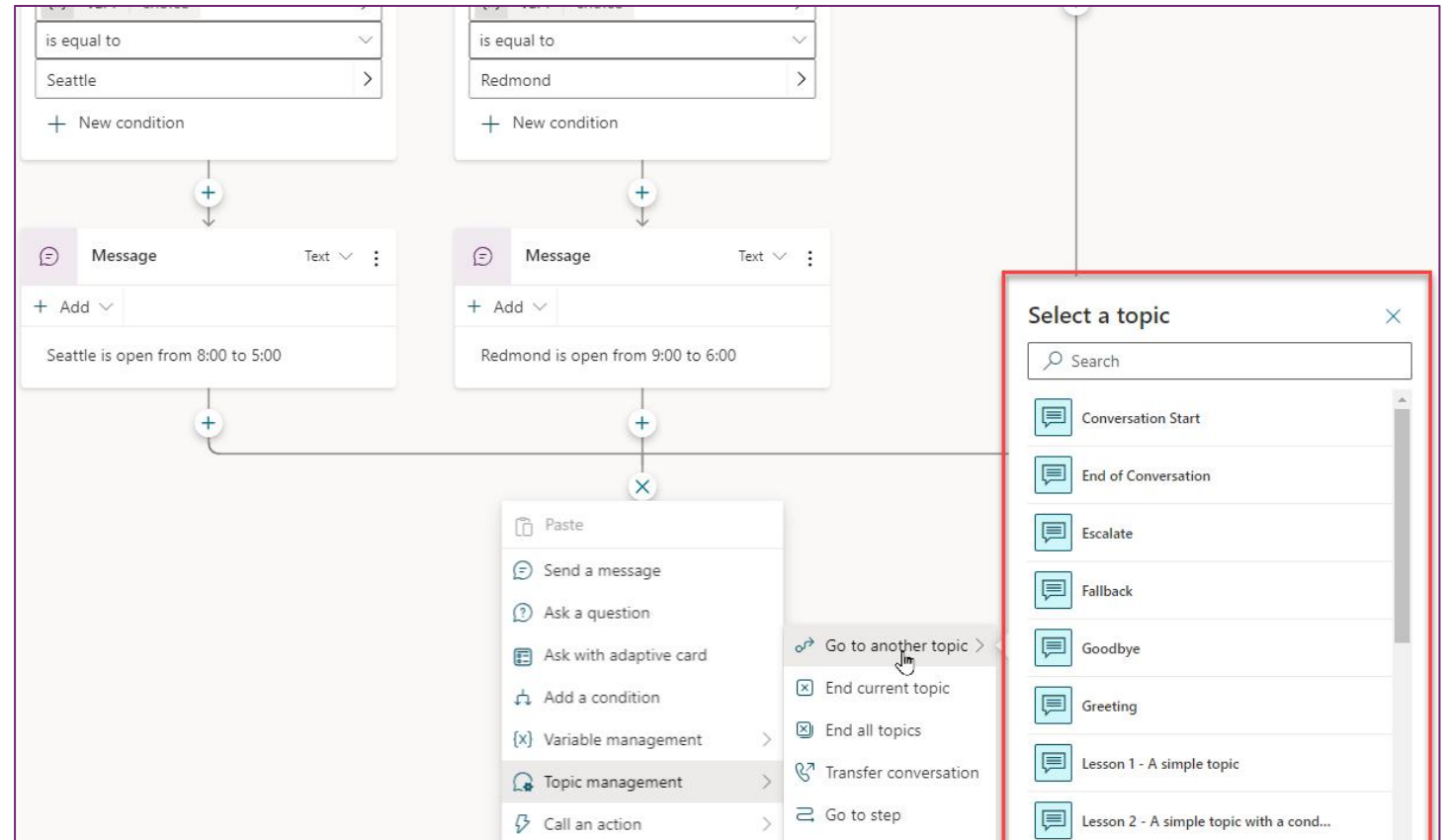
- Define JSON for the card
- JSON is transformed into native UI that automatically adapts to its surroundings



Topic management node

Controls flow between topics

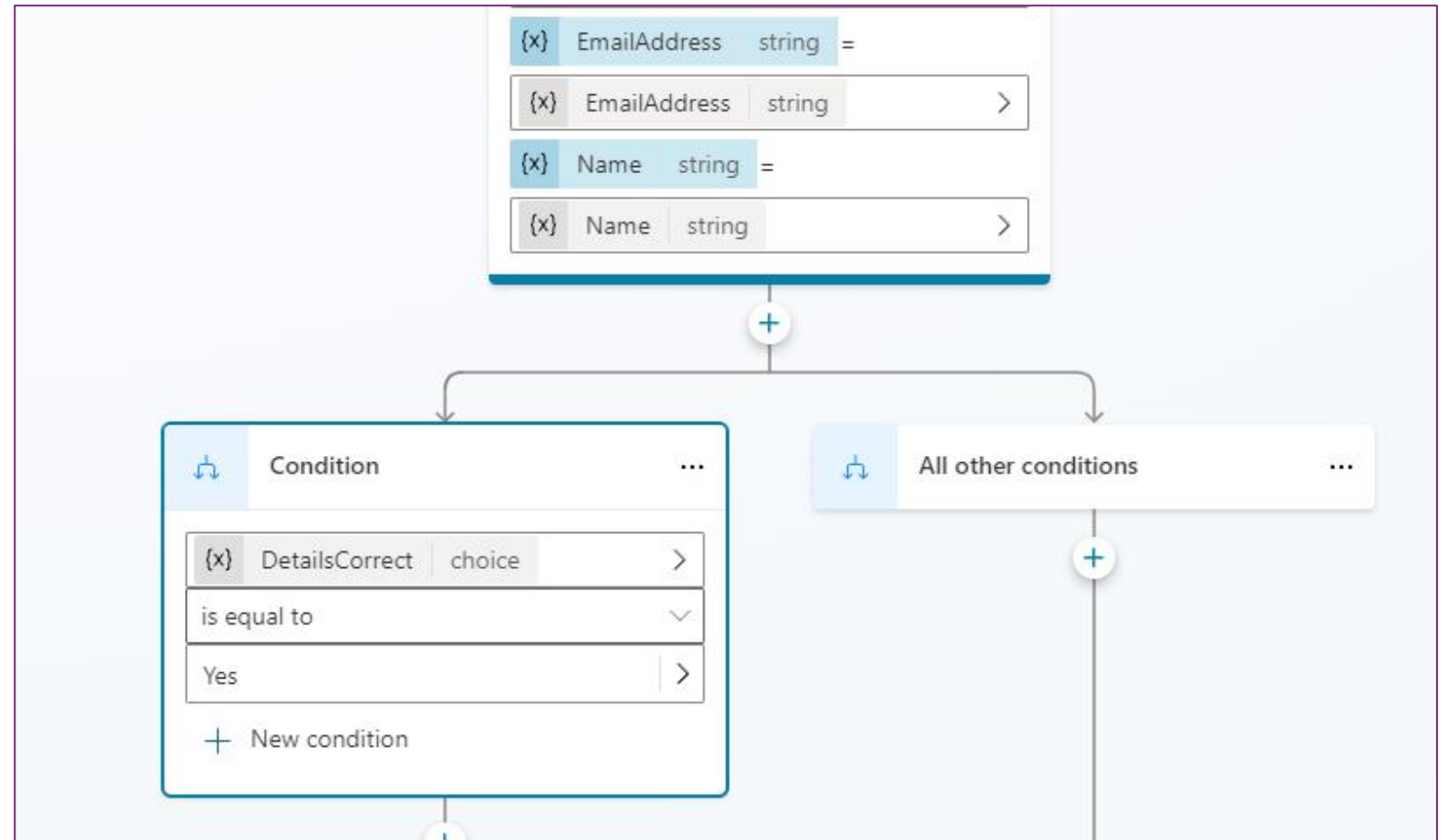
- Go to another topic
- End current topic
- End all topics
- Transfer conversation
- Go to step
- End conversation



Condition node

Branching

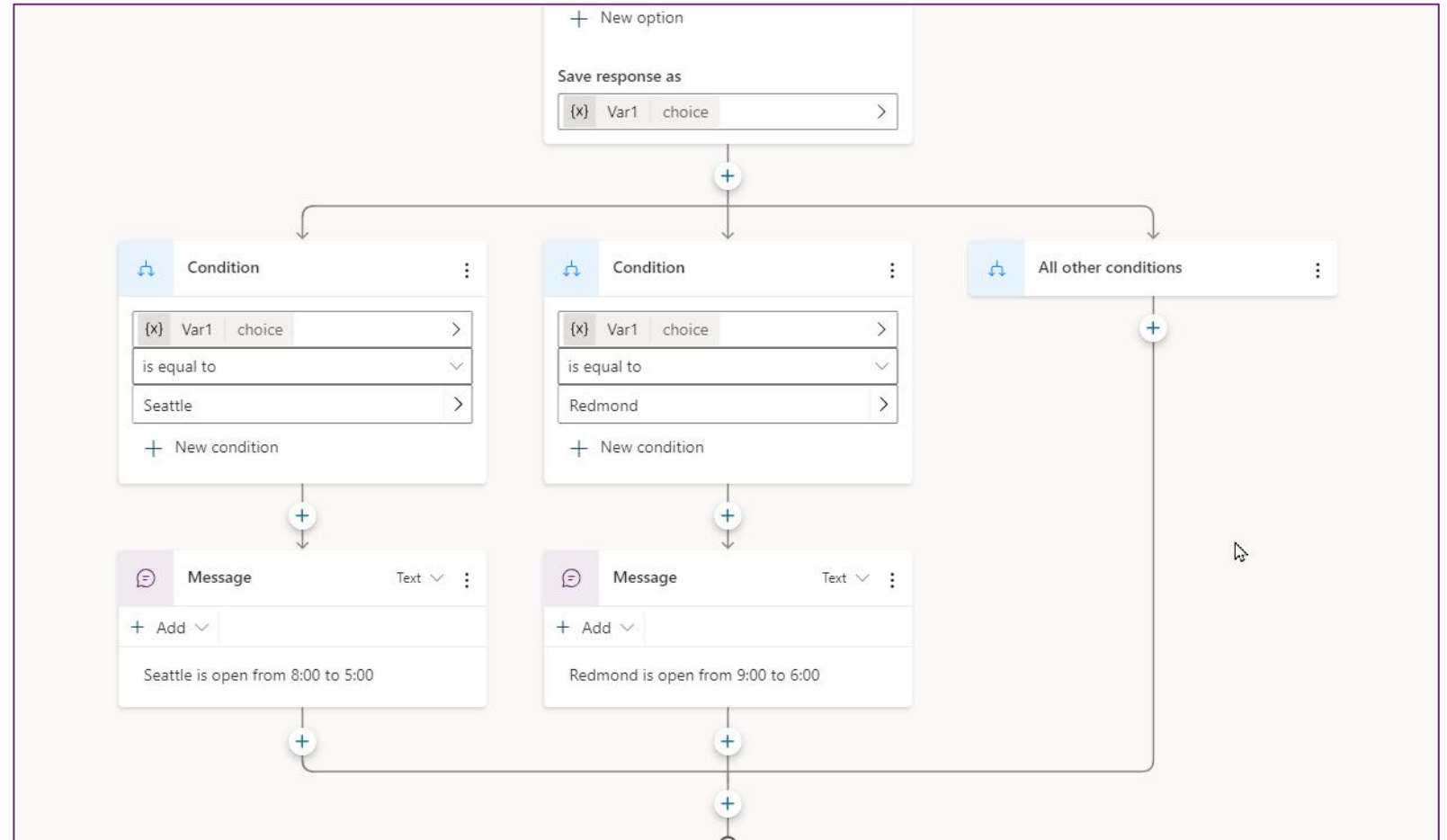
- Compare variable to a value
- If..elseif..elseif..else model



Condition node

Branching

- Compare variable to a value



Add tools to custom agents

What are tools?

- Tools are capabilities that allow your agent to interact with external systems.
- They can be triggered automatically via generative orchestration or explicitly from within a topic.

Mechanisms for adding tools

- **Prebuilt or custom connector**
- **Prompt:** Single-turn AI-powered text generation.
- **Agent Flow:** Multi-step logic with conditions.
- **REST API:** Direct integration with web services.
- **Custom Connector:** Connect to proprietary APIs.
- **MCP Tool:** Access tools via Model Context Protocol server.
- **Computer Use:** GUI automation for desktop/web apps.

Other

- **Skills:** Container for a set of related tools.
- **Client tool:** Execute tools from the client

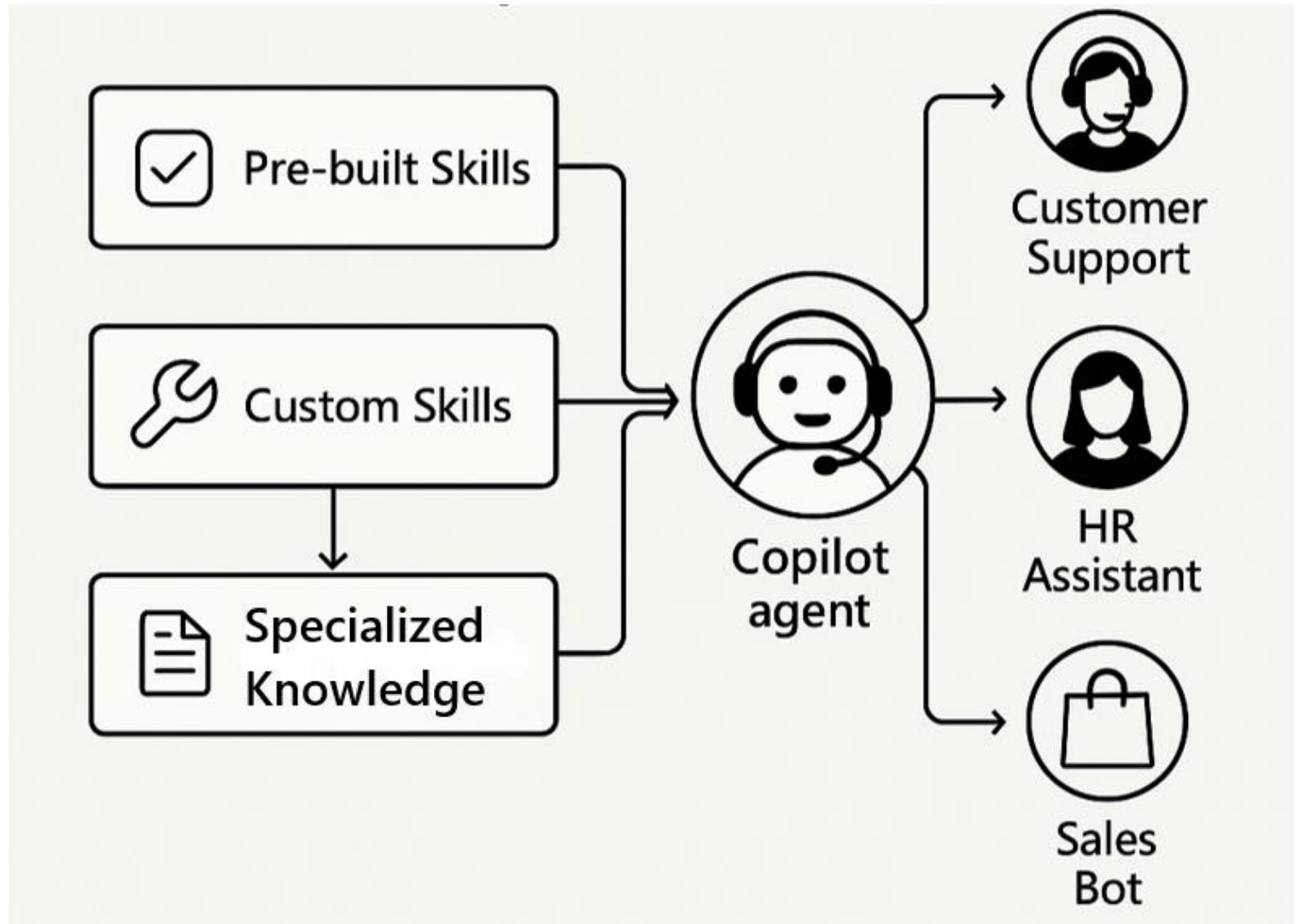
Model Context Protocol (MCP)

- Add AI apps and agents into Copilot Studio with just a few clicks
- Easily connect to data sources with smooth and reliable integration
- Access the marketplace of pre-built, MCP-enabled connectors
- Reduce maintenance and integration costs with flexible action capabilities
- Best for:
 - Seamless, low-latency interactions between agents
 - Scenarios where you want to chain agents together conversationally, but where structured APIs or orchestration are not needed
- Note: Generative orchestration must be enabled to use MCP

Bot Framework Skills

Four key benefits:

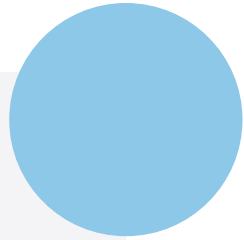
1. **Enhanced Functionality** – Your agents can handle more complex conversations and tasks.
2. **Reusable Components** – Once you build or integrate a skill, you can use it across multiple agents.
3. **Customizable** – You can tailor skills to meet your unique business needs.
4. **Seamless Integration** – Skills fit right into Copilot Studio without requiring major changes.



Demo – Add nodes



Practice Labs



Lab 3: Build an initial agent

Lab 4: Manage topics

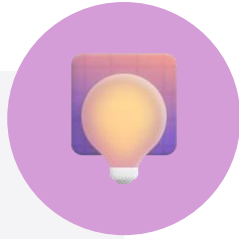
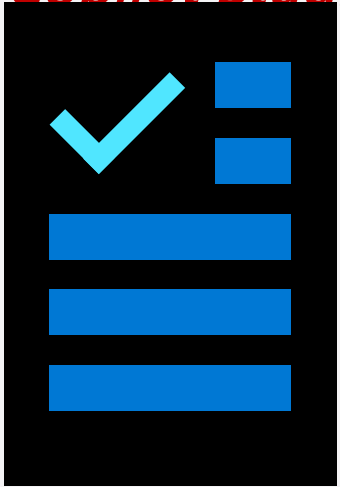
Lab 5: Manage nodes

Knowledge Check



Knowledge Check

*Manage topics
in Microsoft
Copilot Studio*



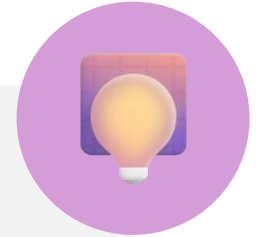
Module 2

1. Use your PC or mobile device
2. Go to (*insert polling app link of your choice*)
3. Enter code: **123-45-678**
4. Please participate

Which one?

- A. None
- B. A little
- C. Lots

Knowledge Check



1 Which component in Microsoft Copilot Studio is used to define the conversation path in an agent?

Actions

Entities

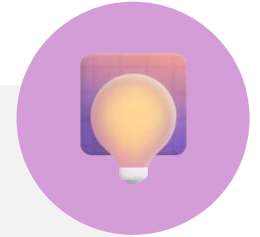
✓ Topics

Variables

Solution

Answer=C

Knowledge Check



2 You recently created a new agent that is used to help in customer support scenarios. You have several topics that were created by default that you want to disable. Which of the following topic types can be turned off?

System topics

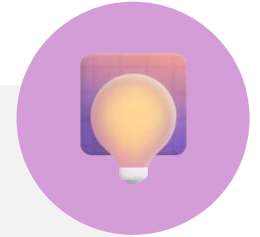
Custom topics

✓ All of the above

Solution

Answer=D

Knowledge Check



3 Currently, when your agent is unable to identify which topic to present to a customer, it automatically escalates the conversation to a live agent. You've been asked to configure the agent to first ask the customer a few questions to determine if a topic can help before escalating the conversation. Which topic should you use?

On error

Multiple Topics Matched



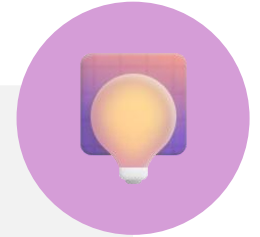
Fallback

Conversational boosting

Solution

Answer=C

Knowledge Check



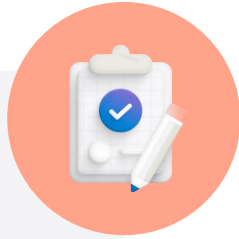
4 You're creating a topic that provides the local weather forecast to a customer. Which conversation node would you use to launch a Power Automate cloud flow to get forecast details from a weather service?

- ✓ Ask a question
- Call an action
- End the conversation
- Go to another topic

Solution

Answer=B

Summary



- Agent topics can be created manually with trigger phrases
- Agent topics can be created and edited by using natural language
- Natural language understanding identifies the user's intent and helps the agent determine the topic or action to use
- Topics can be deleted or disabled
- Nodes control the conversational flow

Module Recap

In this module, we:

Learned how to create topics using Copilot and by adding trigger phrases

Learned how to delete and disable topics

Learned how to configure nodes

